

FRANK ATTLA YOUTH & SLED DOG CARE-MUSHING PROGRAM

[Frank Attla Youth & Sled Dog Care Mushing Program video](#)

The foundation of the **Frank Attla Youth & Sled Dog Care-Mushing Program (FAYSDP)** is to provide young people with hands-on experience working with sled dogs under the guidance and mentorship of experienced dogmen and Native elders. This grassroots pilot program was made possible through the assistance of local sled dog kennel owners/mushers who provided dogs and other assistance. The FAYSDP has been part of the curriculum of the Jimmy Huntington School (JHS) for four years (2012, 2013, 2014, 2015) and involved over 30 high school and middle school students. High school students earned academic credit by taking a veterinarian science class from an accredited animal husbandry teacher. The middle school students earned credit by taking a class related to their Native cultural heritage.

Kennel owners/mushers, the JHS teaching staff, local AmeriCorps service members, and approximately 50 community volunteers worked together to plan classes and to support youth in hosting their own junior sled dog races on weekends. FAYSDP school based classes worked to improve student literacy and numerical skills while the kennel based classes taught dog care related to feeding, maintaining a dog yard, and monitoring overall dog health. All of the FAYSDP students learned dog handling and mushing skills involving harnessing, hooking up, training, and racing a team.

Both school based and dog yard kennel classes offered students a unique opportunity to practice leadership and life skills. With help from their community, the program's high school and middle school students mentored 60 kindergarten to six grade students and a group of National Head Start Association youngsters.

Participation in the FAYSDP had a noticeably positive effect, including an increase in students attaining their school's honor roll and teachers reporting that participating students were more engaged in learning and had a more positive attitude toward education. Students in the program shared that they felt happy working with sled dogs and their parents reported an increase in self-esteem. Some adult members of the Huslia community expressed their belief that young people naturally feel more at ease with themselves when working with dogs because a dog accepts any person without judgment.

Program Highlights: Over the winters of 2012-2013 and 2013-2014, the community of Huslia, JHS students, and George Attla raised funds for junior mushers to compete in championship races. In 2012-2013, two junior dog handlers assisted

two junior mushers to compete in the 4-dog and 6-dog class of the 2013 Junior North American Championship held in North Pole, Alaska. In 2013-2014, two junior dog handlers assisted one junior musher to compete in the 6-dog class of the 2014 Junior North American Championship. This young musher won all three-race heats to become Huslia's first Junior North American Champion. Also, another Huslia junior musher was selected by the state to represent Alaska in the 2014 Arctic Winter Games held in Fairbanks, Alaska. It was the first time a Huslia junior musher competed in the Arctic Winter Games. This young musher won two out of three race heats to win a silver medal for Alaska. With the help of the community over both winters, all of students in the FAYSDP worked together to care for and train the dogs used in these championship races.

Over the winter of 2014-2015, a FAYSDP graduate was mentored by George Attla while also enrolled full-time at the University of Alaska, Fairbanks (UAF) via their distant education program. He helped teach the FAYSDP classes to students who, in turn, helped him care for and train a sprint race dog team to compete in adult open class championship races. This young musher raced in the Open North American Championship to represent the FAYSDP and the community of Huslia. Over this past winter of 2015-2016, the community of Huslia continues to run the FAYSDP for 9th grade students.

Resources
For
Frank Attla Youth and Sled Dog Program

About the educational program website

20 things that working with sled dogs can teach youth

About Huslia's First youth and sled dog program

**Media Links about Huslia's FRANK ATTLA YOUTH & SLED
DOG CARE-MUSHING PROGRAM**

Big Dreams (Mushing Magazine)

Quotes from Huslia's Jimmy Huntington School students

Huslia JHS High school teacher letter of support of FAYSDP

YKSD Superintendent letter of support of FAYSDP

UAF Department of Veterinary Medicine support of FAYSDP

VILLAGE MUSHING DESERVES BACKUP(Fairbanks News-Miner)

Purina Supports FAYSDP -film link #3..on.page

George Attla – Making of a Champion

www.attlamakingofachampion.com

Learn about the history of sled dog racing in Alaska and one man's determination to succeed on this web site about the life of legendary sprint racer, George Attla. The wide range of media found here tells about George - his experiences, accomplishments, and work and life philosophies including the importance of Athabascan values to his success. Navigate through the many videos, images, articles, and narratives, and discover the people, dogs, and events that were important in shaping George's abilities as a dogman and his champion mind-set. The content of this site has something for every viewer and learner. George's commitment to sharing what he has learned about training and racing sled dogs, and his passion to communicate his message about being a winner are evident throughout.



George Attla - Making of a Champion

54 Years of Competitive Sled Dog Racing: 1958-2011



- HOME
- THE MINDSET OF A CHAMPION
- MEET THE MAN
- SPRINT RACING
- AKSHOF
- BOOKS & MOVIES
- HISTORY
- PEOPLE
- ABOUT



Keep a Can-Do Attitude!

KNOW you are a winner. • Don't be a give up person! • Trust your instincts. • Cultivate a strong will. • Learn to handle yc

The Race



THE RACE (Excerpts) Get a glimpse of the thrill of high-speed sled dog racing as ...

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The Mindset of a Champion



George Attla says winning is all in the head. He explains a champion always ...

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Get Involved - Start Mushing!



Learn about Dog Mushing
Welcome Beginners! If you are a beginner musher and want ...

[Read More](#)

Visit a Dog Mushing Museum



The only Dog Mushing Museum in Fairbanks is in the same building as the ...

[Read More](#)

August 2012: “20 things that working with sled dogs can teach youth”

by George Attla of Huslia, Alaska

About sled dogs:

- learn how to care for sled dog: good dog care every day is the most important thing in owning a team of sled dogs. This includes feeding each dog properly as the weather changes, making sure each dog has a good house, bedding, and a chain, a properly fitted collar, checking their feet and nails, checking their teeth and eyes, and more.
- learn how to read a dog. Each dog has its own personality. Dogs are always communicating and it takes study to understand their body language and behavior.
- learn how to handle each dog including fitting a harness, hooking and unhooking to the gang-line, and more.
- learn how to communicate with each dog to get its best performance
- learn how to be a dog trainer. This includes knowing how to train a leader, how to place team dogs, how to judge each dog's strengths and weaknesses, how each dog runs and all its behaviors while running. A dog never makes a mistake- it is the dog trainer who makes the mistakes.
- learn how all the many different kinds of equipment are used to run dogs including sleds, hooks, brakes, gang-lines made of towlines and necklines, etc., and the limitations of each.
- learn about weather and how this affects training trails, all mushing equipment, dogs ability to run, how to maintain your own body temperature, and more.
- learn how to measure and judge distance. This can include using a training tool like a GPS that can calculate running times, split times, maximum speed, minimum speed, and more. The better one understands each dog the better one can catch a problem before it happens.
- learn how to be prepared for any situation. This includes anticipating problems before they happen.
- learn how to quickly troubleshoot and solve problems in the dog yard and out on the trail.

About yourself:

- learn how to eat well and take care of your body
- learn how to dress well and stay warm and comfortable in every possible winter condition
- learn how stay in good physical condition
- learn how to handle a sled on all kinds of trails and in all kinds of snow and weather conditions
- learn how to handle your body; dogs are stronger than you are so you must learn to use your body and not get hurt
- learn how to control your emotions at all times
- learn how keep a good attitude for yourself and for your dogs
- learn how to manage your time each day to accomplish all necessary chores for owning a dog team
- learn how to think ahead and manage supplies necessary to keep dogs healthy; to care for 20 dogs year-round it takes 3 tons of dry commercial dog food, 1 ton of fish or meat or chicken, 1000 lbs of rice, 25 gallons of oil, 30 bales of straw, and medicine when needed.
- learn how to be responsible and make a commitment; dog care and training requires both

One day in the life of a person who owns 20 sled dogs

Split wood and start a fire under a dog pot cooker filled with 10 gallons of water. Add meat, or fish, or chicken, and cook. Prepare a water broth from leftovers from the day before and 'water' all dogs. In the summer by boat, check a net that was set the day before. It takes 6 fish and a half-gallon of rice to feed 20 dogs. After all is cooked, bail out food mixture into buckets to cool. Feed dogs at 7pm after heat of the day. In winter, 15 lbs of meat replaces the fish, and half-gallon of rice is cooked. When hot mixture cools, up to 4 gallons of dry dog food and fish oil is added and fed warm. If cold, more meat, fish, or chicken and fat is added. Everyday all year, pick up after dogs and check their health. Make any dog yard repairs and do all chores necessary to prepare for next day. In fall, winter, and spring, train and race dogs. Every day, take good care of yourself including eating 3 good meals. In the evening, it is time to relax and maybe read a good story!

December 31, 2012

About Huslia's First youth and sled dog program

The ***Frank Attla Youth & Sled Dog Care-Mushing Program*** is based in Huslia, Alaska and it is managed entirely by volunteers. The program was envisioned and started by legendary champion sprint sled dog racer and elder, George Attla. The program is named after his late son, Frank. The program has taken root in the curriculum of the Jimmy Huntington School with some dog care product and shipping support from *Redpaw Feed, Inc.* (a high performance dog food company), *Alaska 4-H* (University of Alaska Co-op Extension Service), and *Ruby Marine* (an Interior Alaska barge company). At this time, the program involves high school and middle school students. High school student participants in the program are enrolled in a veterinary science class, and the middle school student participants are enrolled in a math and science class. High school students are receiving dual high school and college credit for completing the class. In March 2013, there are plans to incorporate elementary students so that all youth will have a chance to participate in the program.

The foundation of the program is the youth's hands-on work with sled dogs. A yard of sled dogs offer a positive and enriching emotional experience to any individual without human judgment. The immediate 'acceptance' that happy and healthy sled dogs offer by their behavior, helps youth feel 'up' and to naturally feel good about themselves. George Attla believes that dogs are the key to helping youth become and remain stable and healthy-minded.

The program design encourages the development of *pride* by learning-by-doing. Additionally, literacy and numeracy skills are incorporated to support young people's academic success and future careers. Field classes, taught by senior mushers of four kennels in Huslia, are held twice a week for each participating age group. High school students are paired with middle school students to mutually assist each other learn about dog care including feeding, cleaning a dog yard, and monitoring overall dog health. Students develop dog handling and mushing skills; handle dogs on a chain; harness and hook up dogs to the gang-line; and mush and eventually race a team of dogs.

The teaching of dog care and mushing focuses on skills, which are associated with specific life skills ("Mushing Spirit"):

Student Benefits :

- Altruism by helping dogs and people
- Perseverance
- Confidence
- Partnership and community spirit

Dog Mushing Skill

Mushing Spirit

Regular care of dogs and equipment	Be responsible - be someone who is known for honoring commitments
Read the strengths and weakness of dogs	Become more adept at knowing people - know who you can draw upon for strength and who you can help to be stronger
Caring for dogs and yourself	Care for yourself - eat healthy food, practice good hygiene and be physically fit
Communicate to achieve high performance	Self-confidence to express yourself honestly
Train dogs	Set goals and develop strategies to achieve them
Know how to regulate your body temperature	Know how to maintain a positive attitude (not too hot, not too cold)
Acquire and maintain your equipment	Access and know to use the resources you need to succeed. e.g. computers, libraries, machine tools, sleds

Know the trail and factors that will affect it e.g. weather and flooding	Anticipate challenges and how they can be overcome. Appreciate that many obstacles cannot be controlled and learn to adapt accordingly
Learn how to ride the runners	Maintain physical balance which assists with mental balance
Be able to recognize and solve problems	All problems have solutions
Enjoy the ride	Have fun and appreciate and enjoy the beauty and wonder of nature
	Other possible lessons or qualities • Know you are a winner. • Trust your instincts. • Cultivate a strong will. • Learn to handle yourself. • Trust your instincts

A curriculum for each grade range is being developed to support hands-on learning. These materials will draw upon existing materials and research of native communities, with the added benefit of local youth serving organizations. The overall program approach creates a new opportunity for leadership within the community, facilitates inter-generational learning, and allows the teaching of program lessons in creative ways suitable to village life (i.e. taking classes to a dog yard, youth participation in race events, etc.).

The program has plans to expand to more community members since volunteers will also work with youth in the four local kennels and to share their skills related to sled dogs. At this time, high school students taking a school shop class are learning to build doghouses with the guidance of experienced dog mushers and carpenters. The community is currently thinking of more ways to expand their involvement including teaching youth to build sleds; to make dog training and racing gear; to sew dog collars and harnesses; and more. These kinds of activity will support more individualized learning and engage broader community participation. Elders, parents, and young adults are invited to support youth education since their involvement is critical for the success of the program and is a leadership opportunity.

A significant part of the program is to monitor youth mental and emotional health as a measure of its effectiveness and success. Assessing impact in this way will support the refinement of the program and its expansion. Mental and emotional health records will be kept by teachers during the entire school year. Parents will all also provide information about their child's behavior and attitude. All record-keeping methods will be reviewed by mental health professionals so the most useful data are collected.

Frank Attla Youth & Sled Dog Care-Mushing Program Progress Report and Timeline:

•**August through September 2012:** Youth were invited to work in sled dog kennels before school and the program started. Approximately 12 youth, a mix of high school and middle school age, participated. The principal and teachers created the plan for incorporating the program into the school curriculum and class schedule.

•**October 2012:** Twice a week high school students enrolled in a Veterinary Science class participate in a 'field class.' On Tuesdays from 10:30 – 12:00, fourteen students are split to work in two local sled dog kennels. On Thursdays during the same time period, the same students are split to work in two other local sled dog kennels. Students learn basic dog care and handling from actually working in four local kennels. On every other Friday, students learn in a classroom setting.

•**November 2012:** High school students continue field classes (split at kennels). Eighteen Middle school students are added to the program including attending field classes at local sled dog kennels. The middle school students will learn the same things about dog care as the high school students.

December 2012: Field classes for high school and middle school students continue and advanced skills having to do with handling, harnessing, and running sled dogs. Unusual lack of snow has limited runs of dogs but other related skills are taught.

January 2013: Field classes for both high school and middle school students start again after holiday break. All ages are taught more about running dog and racing skills (a total of 8 classes per week). Youth are begun how to organize and hold a race (i.e. learn to keep time, prepare sleds, gear, and more).

February 2013: Field classes for both high school and middle school students continue. A Fairbanks area veterinarian is scheduled to travel to Huslia to teach youth on February 1st. The community plans youth sled dog race event with mostly middle school students. Kennel owners provide the sled dogs to make the events possible. At least one young musher travels with dog team to Fairbanks to compete in the Junior North American World Championship. George Attla works to get sponsor support to bring to town more youth to be dog handlers for classmates, and also maybe adult mushers competing in championship sprint and distance races.

March 2013: Skijoring will be added to the field classes so youth can learn skills using only one dog so they can safely practice and have fun with dogs on weekends (even their own house dogs :). More youth run dog teams. Elders and other dogmen teach youth what they know about sled dog care and training. Elementary school students go to Attla kennel to learn about sled dogs. A Junior Spring Carnival, consisting of sled dog races and snowshoe races for all ages, plus a banquet and awards ceremony will take place over two days around mid-month. Youth will be part of planning and event and the work necessary to make it happen.

April 2013: Field classes for both high school and middle school students continue. With warmer weather, youth spend more time running dog teams and skijoring during class, and also after school. More kennel visits by elementary school students. If there is interest, Attla kennel invites Head Start youngsters to pet puppies.

May 2013: Field classes for students of all ages continue until school ends. More skills relating to dog care as spring ends and summer begins. Youth do last work in kennels during break-up. Make plans for summer fishing and care for the sled dogs that were used in program.

June through August 2013:

Summer sled dog care classes will be available for all interested youth. Though school is out of session, all the dogs in the four kennels still need care. There are also countless dog yard chores to do including fixing and building dog houses and pens, caring and handling of new pups. Also start fishing for dogs: first whitefish, then salmon. End summer cutting grass on edge of lakes for dog houses in winter.

September through December 2013: The youth and sled dog program starts again as part of the school curriculum. More ages are incorporated as the school schedule allows and community involvement increases (i.e. adult volunteers).

FALL of 2012 through Spring of 2015: Media Links about Huslia's *FRANK ATTILA YOUTH* & *SLED DOG CARE-MUSHING PROGRAM*

•**MOST RECENT:** See two Fundraiser links with exciting current FAYSDP information:

<https://www.kickstarter.com/projects/1103707231/attla-a-new-documentary-film>

<https://www.indiegogo.com/projects/help-huslia-s-young-dog-mushers-race-this-winter>

•**Alaska Newspaper:** See four articles in the *Fairbanks Daily News-Miner*:

http://www.newsminer.com/news/kris_capps/museum-opening/article_5fc50652-30d5-11e4-a56b-001a4bcf6878.html

http://www.newsminer.com/sports/local_community/second-means-first-at-junior-north-american-mushing-championships/article_c4064a9e-a828-11e3-920d-001a4bcf6878.html

http://www.newsminer.com/news/local_news/alaska-native-mushing-icon-george-attla-hopes-to-boost-sport/article_8b556ae8-3b92-11e3-822b-001a4bcf6878.html?mode=image&photo

http://www.newsminer.com/sports/local_community/article_ec615d16-80b9-11e2-b984-0019bb30f31a.html

http://www.newsminer.com/features/our_town/stories_of_our_town/huslia-students-learn-about-life-culture-by-working-with-sled/article_a63114e0-9906-11e2-9e56-0019bb30f31a.html?mode=story

•**Statewide Newsletter:** See Spring 2013 issue of RurAL CAP *Village Voices Newsletter*, p. 4 & 5:

http://ruralcap.com/index.php?option=com_content&view=article&id=189&Itemid=89

•**Alaska School District Newsletter:** See two articles in two issues of Yukon-Koyukuk School District *Staff Connections Newsletter*: 2nd Quarter December 2012 issue, p. 16 & 17 and 3rd Quarter March 2013 issue, p. 8:

<http://www.yksd.com/domain/5>

•**Alaska Radio:** See March 2013 *KUAC Radio* news feature:

<http://fm.kuac.org/post/huslia-program-gets-kids-mushing>

•**Alaska TV Show:** See March 2013 *Alaska Political Insider* show:

<http://www.youralaskalink.com/politics>

•**Alaska-based Educational Web Site:**

<http://awg2014.smugmug.com/Dog-Mushing>

•**Alaska Foundation Web Site:** See Fall 2012 issue of *Alaska Humanities FORUM Magazine*:

<http://akhfblog.typepad.com/door-15/2012/11/new-forum-magazine-available-online.html>

•**Alaska On-line Newspaper Snippet:** See March 2013 on-line article of *Alaska Daily News*:

<http://www.adn.com/2013/03/04/2812086/meet-the-sled-dogs-dozer.html>

•**Nationwide News Release:** See *Alaska Education Library* on Alaska U.S. Senator web site and ANNAET Petfoods Inc. sponsorship announcement:

<http://www.murkowski.senate.gov/public/index.cfm?p=ak-education-success>

<http://annamaet.com/>

•**National Magazine:** See articles in three issues of *Mushing Magazine* ("*BIG DREAMS*" in May/Jun 2013 starts on page 3):

<http://www.mushing.com/generalstore/product.php?lockey=3&uid=59&page=1>

<http://attlamakingofachampion.com/wp-content/uploads/2011/12/2012.03-Mushing-Magazine-Part-II-Attla.pdf>

<http://attlamakingofachampion.com/wp-content/uploads/2012/02/2012.01-Mushing-Magazine-Part-I-Attla2.pdf>

BIG DREAMS

Sled Dog School - Frank Attla Youth & Sled Dog Care Program

By Bridget Schwafel, Images by Kathy Turco

Happy kids. Happy dogs. Those are the phrases I heard most often associated with the Frank Attla Youth and Sled Dog Care Program. There is no doubt that the brainchild of George Attla, Jr. to increase interest in sled dog racing in his home village of Huslia is a huge success.

The program has been embraced in the village, and is having a positive effect on everyone involved. It seems as if the entire community is involved. George and his partner, Kathy Turco, are the driving forces behind the program, and together they lit the spark that spread like lightening through the village of about 280 people.

The youth and sled dog program grew out of George's tenacity to fulfill his hope and a dream to keep the sport of dog racing alive and strong in Huslia and the Koyukuk region, an area that had been famous since 1956 when Jimmy Huntington from Huslia won the Anchorage Fur Rendezvous with dogs pooled from the Koyukuk River area—for decades to come these were the teams to beat. The area was famous for producing the fastest dogs in the world and racing-dogs worldwide can still trace their bloodlines back to dogs from the region. George wanted to bring back to the community the collective pride in raising, caring for, training and racing sled dogs. George envisioned a program that would create an environment to strengthen young people physically and mentally, and to pull together a community across generations in a shared cause to reawaken the sled dog pride and tradition. He dedicated the program to his late son, Frank Attla.

When I heard that George had started the Frank Attla Youth and Sled Dog Care Program in Huslia, I thought how fitting that



Above left to right: Frank Attla at the 2000 Junior North American Championships. Photo by Robert Drozda. • Frank Attla at 2008 Koyukuk River Championship Race in Huslia. Photo by Patti Brown

Frank's legacy should be one of continuing to help kids and dogs. Frank died unexpectedly from complications of a severe asthma attack in the spring of 2010. He had just returned to Alaska after completing boot camp for the Army Reserve. Since early childhood, Frank wanted to become a policeman, and this was to be a step along that path.

I remember Frank Attla as a mischievous joker, always smiling while chattering away and horsing around with his many friends. At the junior sled dog races in Fairbanks he was always on hand to hold sleds, help get a team to the start line, pick up a stranded musher on the trail, or pitch in wherever help was needed. When he was about eleven years old, his chatty banter led to his being an announcer during the Junior North American Championship races. He was a pro from the beginning and we had a lot of

fun up in the race tower that year. Shortly after, he moved from North Pole to Huslia, where he continued to help kids who wanted to mush dogs. His dad, George said, "His heart was with the kids...he'd hook up dogs all day long for the kids. He had his own youth program!"

George envisioned the program that had been "a dream of the people who grew up with dogs as a part of their communities and families," according to Cesa Sam, Huslia Tribal Council's Tribal Family Youth Specialist. She said, "Elders know what they (dogs) have done for them,

regarding making them know how to work hard, being able to use them for trapping and fun things like racing, and it builds a lot of self-esteem." She said that no one knew how to get a program like this going, but that George and Kathy had taken the initiative to get it started and keep it going. "I'm totally loving the fact that George and Kathy have been able to figure this out and keep going with it. Every family in one way or another is involved with the program," Sam said. The program's foundation is a massive volunteer effort, and essential to the effort are four kennels owned by mushers Wilson Sam, Wesley Henry, Floyd Vent and George Attla Jr. It's not only the kennel owners who are involved, their entire families are contributing. Cesa Sam said, "The whole family is involved, and all of these people play a big role in keeping the program running. It could never happen without

them.” She said, not only are the mushers “teaching about dogs, they are being role models and mentors” to the students. A student “might be having a bad day and the adults pick up on that; they take time and pay a lot more attention [to that student]. After they leave, they feel better about themselves,” she said.

When I asked Kathy Turco about funding for such a large undertaking, she laughed. She said that what is so wonderful about this program, and “why it is so phenomenal,” is that there hasn’t been much. After the initial and brief involvement of the 4-H Alaska, the school enthusiastically embraced the program and embedded the community-based activities into the school curriculum. Each of the mushers who signed up for the program received 10 bags of dog food (a donation from Red Paw), a few gallons of fish oil, and some straw. Every one of them said they volunteered because it was good for the kids and good for the dogs. They all said they would have done it without any compensation, other than the happiness it brings to the kids and the dogs.

Ruby Marine shipped dog food to Huslia before the rivers froze and contributed money toward the Hugh Bifelt Memorial Race (the spring dog race in Huslia held in March). Cash prizes for sled dog races are a way for mushers to earn a little money. The goal of the racing teams is to win enough money to help offset the cost of dog care. Key to the success of the youth and dogs program has been the kennel owners who signed on to host classes at their kennels for an hour and a half, twice a week.

ROLE MODELS AND MENTORS

It’s a lot of work, kennel owner and musher Wesley Henry said, but he said seeing how much his own five children enjoyed working with the dogs, he thought a few more kids in his dog yard a couple times a week wouldn’t be that much more work. Even though he admits that he didn’t realize how much more time and work would be involved, he doesn’t mind it, and signed up for another year. He said even when the students aren’t there he’s figuring out what’s next for the kids. He wants to give them what Henry calls “the basics.” It turns out “the basics” include quite a lot.

Students who have had the opportunity to spend time with Henry have not only learned about dog care, hooking up and driving dogs, but Henry has also taught them some practical skills that they can put to use to make a living. Henry brought in some of the dog sleds that were in dire need of repair and showed the students how to fix them. They pulled them apart and made the needed repairs, replacing broken parts and retying the sleds. Building on that skill, he thought they should know about building a sled from scratch, and they can also learn to build snowshoes with the same skills.

Teacher Sam Barney is really impressed with Henry teaching his students. After repairing the sleds, Henry took the students on a field trip and taught them how to look for the right birch tree that would have the appropriate grain suitable for the strength and flexibility needed to build a sled. “It’s really a picky process getting the right tree,” Sam Barney said. Henry and the students cut and hauled the tree, milled the logs into boards, and after the boards season this summer, the middle school boys will build a sled next fall.

Students who were shy or scared of the dogs at the start of the program overcame their initial fear and became confident handlers and drivers. By the end of the school year these same students happily interact with the dogs and look forward to seeing them. Henry thinks it changes their whole being and promotes confidence and self-worth



George Atla talks to JHS middle school students about their grandparents and their dogs. Photo by Kathy Turco.

that can be applied to other aspects of their lives.

Kennel owner and volunteer Floyd Vent signed up to help the kids and thought it would be good for the dogs, too. He said dog teams are disappearing from villages. By helping kids get started learning about sled dogs through the program he hopes the interest it instills can help bring back the skills and desire needed to keep the tradition of dog teams in the Koyukuk area villages. He said, “The kids really enjoy the dogs, working with the dogs in the dog yard and mushing, learning about dogs and the care of dogs, training and driving the dog teams.” Helping the students is a family affair. Vent’s wife, Joyce, works as a teacher’s aide and helps out with the classes visiting the kennels.

Vent was an open class sprint racer and his son Alexander Vent, has taken over the racing and care of the dogs. They have about 20 racing dogs, and five pups. When the snow melts and the trails dry out, he’ll start running the dogs with his 4-wheeler, and he expects he’ll see some of the students from the program show up to help over the summer. “If they want to come over and help, they probably would,” he said. Kids just showing up to help out in a dog yard probably wouldn’t have happened before their experience with the program.

This year Alexander won the Koyukuk River Championship (KRC) race in Allakaket. Vent’s daughter, Lois Vent, won the women’s event, and they each brought home cash prizes that help to offset the cost of dog food and care. “It will never come out to what you spent on the dogs,” said Floyd Vent. “It paid for some gas and some dog food we can order this spring,” he said. The KRC race alternates venues among the villages of Huslia, Hughes, and Allakaket/Alatna each spring and it is here that mushers try put their dogs to the test and win back some of the money spent keeping dogs in their kennel healthy and happy all winter. The communities raise a lot of money for the races in the village and share in the expense of the spring carnival events and races at the KRC. The race will be in Huslia next spring.

Funds come primarily from games of chance, including local raffles and Bingo. Participating communities raise upwards of \$20,000 a year to fund the races. Cash prizes trickle down through the community where participants compete in sled dog races including kids, women’s and championship races as well as snow shoe races and other events. Raffles are important fundraisers. Items include beaded gloves, fur ruffs, sleds and snow shoes. (When I’m lucky enough to go

Continued on next page



Huslia Youth Day Races- Jackie Wholescheese and JHS students help musher Tony Sam III at the start. Photo by Leona Starr

to attend village activities, I buy raffle tickets to help fund the event. I still haven't won those beaded gloves!)

Mushers travel to the out-of-town races by hauling their dogs in a dog box towed by a snow machine. Generally it takes a couple days of travel to get to the race. This year, Vent and his sons traveled to Allakaket by a snow machine on the winter trail with an overnight in Hughes. "You have to take your time," Vent said, "you can't bounce (the dogs) around a lot, and you have to stop and take them out, (so they can) run around and stretch and empty out. Quite a trip. I have my boys go with me, with four snow-goes; all the dogs, dog food and the straw and the gear."

You can learn a lot from dogs, Vent says. At first the dogs were as shy of the students as they were of the dogs. After a few visits they learned to trust each other and they all started to have fun. "The kids started to have fun with the dogs because they weren't scared of the dogs anymore. Some of the dogs were a little rough, but after the kids started coming around, the kids started playing with them and it made them happy and it turned out pretty good...one girl was very afraid at first, and by the end of the school year, she wasn't scared anymore, and was having a lot of fun. She really enjoyed it. Not only did it give her a big boost of confidence and pride, by the end of the school year she was really enjoying herself, he said.

"It's good for them to get out running the dogs and following behind on a snow-go. The kids switch off and on from the snow-go to the dog sled. They have a good time."

Vent has been running dogs for about forty years, ever since he was a young boy. He said, "It seems like the kids enjoy the dogs and I like to help them." He felt that they learn more than just about the dogs, they learn a lot about themselves. He related a story about how he saw one student make a big change. He said, "One girl was scared to drive them (the dog team), and ended up not being scared of the dogs and found out she could do it after all!" Vent said he grew up with dogs working on the trapline. He wanted to get involved with the program because he hopes that by seeing the youth really becoming involved, and more people also become involved with dogs.

Another pivotal person is Wilson Sam, who the kids all call Grandpa Wilson. Sam said he had to give up his dream to win the Yukon Quest,

after completing the inaugural race in 1984, because of the cost to keep a dog team in Huslia. He is happy to see the interest in sled dogs being rejuvenated in his community, but he says the hardest part is the money. There are plenty of enthusiastic volunteers who put in countless hours of hard work, but being able to pay for the food and dog care are ultimately what will make the program succeed or fail. The importance of the program can't be underestimated. Wilson Sam and others talked to me about how they thought that it helped prevent suicide among young people.

"We never had this problem (when his generation was young)," he said, "We were too busy to be depressed or bored." The youth of his generation were absorbed in living life. There was too much to do and too much depended on them getting out in the country to make their living by working hard all the time. He's seen kids in the program really get something out of it. Some of the students really hadn't ever had to work before. They didn't know how to work and no one had asked them to or expected them to work. Through the hard work associated with caring for and training dogs, students connect and participate more fully in activities that were common for their parents and grandparents. The program serves to strengthen the bonds between generations.

Sam sees changes in some of the students. He sees much more of his granddaughter, Courtney Agnes, who represented Huslia when



Kathy Turco at Atlla kennel shows JHS students how to cook for dogs. Photo by Sam Barney

she came to Fairbanks to handle dogs for two schoolmates who raced in the Junior North American Championships this spring. Sam said students are much more likely to just stop by for a visit or come by to help him out in the dog yard. They spend time listening to him tell stories, helping in the dog yard, or just hanging out with the dogs. He sees less bullying and sees kids getting along better with each other. He talks to them about how important it is to get along and work as a team.

ANOTHER WAY OF LEARNING

Middle school teacher, Sam Barney, grew up cleaning neighborhood dog yards in Two Rivers, a dog mushing haven just outside of Fairbanks, Alaska. A self-described "huge advocate of place-based" teaching, he likes to take the classroom outdoors to teach subjects

such as biology, natural history and science. He was onboard from the start, and feels that at times “school gets in the way of education.” Barney said he sees students that don’t connect with “book” learning have the opportunity to excel in the dog mushing program. The hands-on learning style keeps them engaged and excited about school. He’s seen some students do a lot better academically and become more involved with school and learning.

Musher Wesley Henry said that the kids are getting a lot out of the program. He identifies with the students who struggle with the traditional western-style classroom setting. He said he struggled with reading and writing and he didn’t have patience to learn in the classroom. Henry has seen students who have trouble with reading and writing in the classroom give 100% in the hands-on learning setting. He has seen students become engaged and attitudes toward learning change during the program. Henry enjoys seeing the students learn the lessons the dogs have to teach. He told the students that they have to listen, even if they think it’s a little thing or not important, it might turn out to be a big thing, so they should listen all the time and try to learn. He gave an example of one boy who hadn’t heard him say to always make sure to hook down a team in solid snow. The boy tried to hook down time after time in the soft snow on the side of the trail. After the dogs pulled the hook several times, the boy finally figured out how to set the hook in solid snow. Henry used that example to remind students to always listen and pay attention. There’s always something important that they might miss, and whether it’s hearing it from the teacher in their classroom, or from an Elder or parent, paying attention is important to learning.

Teacher Sam Barney says that the program is proving to be helpful, especially for students that don’t generally do well with academics. He says sometimes the education system fails kids by the way school is designed, it doesn’t give them other options to learn. This program gives them an option to excel in a class, and not primarily through bookwork. Students are working hands-on. They are engaging with the elders, and with animals,

talking about nature and science, and of keeping animals healthy and happy. It gives students that hands-on learning experience, and it’s made a big difference in some of the



*Wesley Henry shows JHS high school students how to clean dog houses.
Photo by Bill Bruno*

students, particularly in those who generally don’t do well in school are doing a lot better. Barney finds students are more approachable. “They don’t fly off the handle so much, and are calmer. You can sit down and talk to them and work things out now, and talk about how to do things and how to improve,” he said. Students who have a sense of achievement outside of the classroom feel less defensive about the things they do less well in the classroom, he said.

Graduating senior and 2013 valedictorian, Joe Bifelt, is a strong presence and leader in the school and the community. Other boys follow his lead, said high school English and Veterinary Science teacher, Peggy Bruno. He is very influential and helped many other students rise to the top. “I’ve seen changed behavior in students who were somewhat unsuccessful.” These students in particular, she said, have become very successful and she credits their involvement with the “Wonderful, wonderful program!” Bifelt has been accepted to the University of Alaska in Anchorage and Fairbanks, and plans to become a teacher and basketball coach.

KEEPING THE DREAM ALIVE

According to Kathy Turco, at least fifty volunteers are actively involved. That means between the students, school staff, and community volunteers, practically the entire

community is touched by the program in one way or another. And that’s why this program works. It isn’t something that can be picked up and implemented somewhere else, unless the community embraces it in the same way Huslia has. All that was needed to get the program going was the spark, and George and Kathy were that spark.

Last fall, George approached the kennel owners in Huslia with George’s idea, and received extremely positive responses. Then they went to the tribal council and laid out their plan. Cesa Sam said that of course they were in favor of the plan. Then George and Kathy met with the Jimmy Huntington School principal, Teresa Cox, and presented the plan with the four kennels and the Tribal Council behind them.

Principal Cox met with George and Kathy at the school

to hear about their plan. After hearing the proposal, she said, “We can make this work; it’s going to work out great!” When Cox met with the teachers, she told them, “We’re going to do this! This is a good thing.” She said the teachers embraced it, and the program flourished.

The program immediately became integrated into the curriculum. For the River Fisheries class in the fall, students caught fish to feed the dogs in kennels participating in the program. The lessons about animal husbandry (keeping the dog yard clean, fresh straw in the dog houses, and nutrition) fit into the science (middle school) and veterinary science classes (high school). Math was also tied in with calculations for such topics as costs associated with maintaining a dog yard and calculating the amount and cost of dog food. High school students received dual high school and college credit at the University of Alaska for the Veterinary Science class, which will continue next year with Veterinary Science II.

“George is a delight to work with,” said Cox. “All the students call him Grandpa George.”

High School teacher Peggy Bruno is vital to the success of the program. Bruno’s husband, Bill, also volunteers nearly every week to help with the high school classes at the kennels and has taught construction and electrical technology. After retiring from the Missouri school system Bruno and her husband

Continued on page 42.

thought it would be an adventure to teach in Alaska. They didn't expect to call Huslia home.

Bruno has made it her mission to help students graduate. She holds a veterinary

principals six years in a row. In Huslia, there have been three principals in the last four years, according to Sam Barney. The high school history teacher has been new each of the last four years. Even with all the shifts, the school staff in Huslia is considered comparatively stable.

“*Nothing stops George, nothing ever has.*”

technician certification that qualified her to teach Veterinary Science. She said it was serendipitous that she held the right certification for everything to fall into place. The Veterinary Science class centered on activities associated with the Frank Attla Youth & Sled Dog Care Program and students earned dual credit for high school and college. Bruno said Patty Woody, Director of the Yukon-Koyukuk School District's Alaska Career & Technical Education (CTE), was instrumental in setting up and coordinating the class at the University of Alaska Fairbanks.

Sam Barney said he gives huge kudos to the volunteers working, and that the depth of involvement and commitment from the kennels are a key to making the program a success. He feels that there was an intrinsic desire on the community to perpetuate the historic sport and skills associated with dog mushing and racing. He said Wesley Henry showed the students much more than just how to scoop poop. Aside from the dog yard chores, feeding and care, harnessing and hooking up the dog teams, he also taught them about dog sleds and about their own history. Sam Barney says the program seems normal to him, but teachers in other schools seem to think it's something extraordinary.

Asked if he can see a continuation of the program in the school, he said that if the program is in place when new teachers come in, it will just be part of their regular schedule. The strength of it is that it helps integrate the teachers into the community. In the past, there has been a tendency for teachers new to the village way of life to not understand that you don't need an invitation to a community event and if you don't show up, maybe it means you just don't want to meet people.

There's been a revolving door at many village schools, and according to George, several of the nearby villages have had new

Wilson Sam said that the program needs support in the form of dog food if it is to keep going. It has the whole community behind it, and a strong volunteer base. Sam thinks that if more people know about the program, funding would materialize. He would like to see a movie made about the program, and thinks this would spread the word about the benefit of working together as a community with the dog teams. He'd like the movie to include the fish camp where people catch fish to feed their dogs through the winter. This summer the volunteer mushers hope to see students working in the fish camp and learning how to put up fish for the dogs.

REACHING BEYOND HUSLIA

The news about the Frank Attla Youth and Sled Dog Care Program isn't just spreading around Alaska. Teresa Cox said the school has been getting calls from around the country. George was invited to the Northwest Territories and visited four villages in the McKenzie River Delta area in late March to talk about how a program modeled on the Youth and Sled Dog Care Program could be started in their communities. In late March George spent ten days visiting and speaking about the program in Tuktoyaktuk, Inuvik, Aklavik, and Fort McPherson, NWT.

George's ties to the dog mushers in that area go way back. Peter Norberg from Tuktoyaktuk, as a young musher, made his way to George's house in the winter of 1978. George sold him seventeen young dogs that helped Peter to win the 1981 North American Championship in Fairbanks. Many years later George visited Tuktoyaktuk for the first time, where the friends and family of the late Peter Norberg greeted him with much warmth and appreciation and gave George two of

Norberg's dog harnesses and his snowshoes as tokens of their friendship.

DREAM REALIZED

It's been a few years since George talked to me about how important it was to bring pride in racing sled dogs back into the villages. He spoke about how today's youth did not know their own history, their family connections, or the places they came from, and how important it was that they knew and had pride in who they are as people. He believed that if kids were involved with dogs, the connection with historical pride and traditional knowledge could strengthen and help them become stronger physically and mentally. It would also help keep his dream to reinvigorate sled dog racing in the Koyukuk region. It seems George was right.

George said that teachers in Huslia have told him that students' grades and attitudes are improving. Students drop by (outside of class) to visit and learn about their past and their traditions from Grandpa George, Grandpa Wilson, and other elders in the community. Teachers and parents report students getting along better and being happier, and talk about improving confidence and self-esteem. Students are often seen running dog teams around town and in the community races, and helping each other handle the teams.

George says dogs have a lot to teach people. He said, "A dog does not have an opinion about a person. They accept all people. A dog that will accept you just the way you are." The trait modeled by dogs every day (one of unconditional acceptance for every person regardless of who they are or what their problems are), helps build student confidence and strengthen relationships.

When George told me about his dream, it hardly seemed possible, but nothing stops George. Nothing ever has. He says if you see a wall, just keep pounding until you get through it. With George's vision, tenacity and wisdom, and Kathy's positive attitude, persistence and ability to see past the obstacles, they are an unstoppable team and the entire region is benefiting. The kids and dogs are healthy and happy. What more could you ask for (besides some dog food)? •

**May 2013: Quotes from Huslia's Jimmy Huntington School students about their
FRANK ATTLA YOUTH & SLED DOG CARE-MUSHING PROGRAM**

I personally love the program because I like to race and compete. I think that this program was a really nice idea, and it will put Huslia back on the map.

Jimmy Huntington School 7th grader

The experience we got from working with the dogs will be useful in the future. I like the program because my grandpa used to work with his dogs.

Jimmy Huntington School 7th grader

I love the Huslia youth and sled dog program because we are all learning about our culture.

Jimmy Huntington School 7th grader

I like our Huslia sled dog program because we learn a lot about our culture, and we have friendship with the dogs. I love racing.

Jimmy Huntington School 7th grader

I like our Huslia youth and sled dog program because it is fun racing the dogs. The dogs are like friends to us.

Jimmy Huntington School 7th grader

I like the program because of how old people traveled long ago.

Jimmy Huntington School 8th grader

I really like the class. In my class we've been going to my Grandpa Wilson's and Grandpa George's. When going to the dog yard the fun thing to do is play with the dogs.

Jimmy Huntington School 8th grader

I love this program because it gets teens out and enjoy the outside. I love skijoring and mushing with the dogs when we go to Kathy and George's house every Thursday and Wilson's every Tuesday.

Jimmy Huntington School 8th grader

I've enjoyed taking this class because I like to be outside and experience running dogs; it is very peaceful. I am looking forward to taking the class next year.

Jimmy Huntington School 9th grader

I like our Huslia youth and sled dog program because I get to learn how to run dogs. We also get to feed them and play with them. We all like to take care of the dogs because it is really fun.

Jimmy Huntington School 9th grader

Because of the program we have learned so much about dogs and more of our tradition.

Jimmy Huntington School 9th grader

I like our dog mushing program because I never did any thing like this before and I'm glad to have gotten the chance to. I am looking forward to doing this next year because it is so peaceful and beautiful.

Jimmy Huntington School 9th grader

I like our Huslia youth and sled dog program because it has taught us so much and it has been so enjoyable.

Jimmy Huntington School 9th grader

I really like this class because I like to run dogs. I also like the part where we went skijoring with the dogs. I got to know Grandpa George more with the program.

Jimmy Huntington School 10th grader

I like this program because I like to help people out, the dogs are so nice and friendly, and I love to run and play with the dogs.

Jimmy Huntington School 10th grader

I like our youth and sled dog program because it keeps young teens active. It is really fun to work with dogs and learn to mush. It is a great experience.

Jimmy Huntington School 10th grader

We enjoy our youth and sled dog program because it is a program that helps keep youth away from drugs and alcohol. We also like it because it is our culture. It was once a way of life.

Jimmy Huntington School 10th grader

I personally enjoy the program because it keeps the youth active and creates plenty of fun for both youth and Elders.

Jimmy Huntington School 12th grader

August 12, 2014

To Whom It May Concern:

I've taught seventh and eighth grade at Jimmy Huntington School for the past five years. For the last two years I worked closely with George Attla, Kathy Turco, Floyd Vent, Wes Henry, Wilson Sam and many others in the community to integrate a youth dog sled mushing program, that George was spearheading, into the school. Over the extent of those two years I've personally had about twenty-five students (not to include all the high school students that were a part of the program) who have participated in this program during school hours.

These students have had experience with and participated in lessons related to: veterinary care of sled dogs, assisting in giving shots, setting an I.V., feeding and general care, anatomy of race dogs, details of training and importance of keeping good records, time keeping, the physics behind dog sleds, they helped build a dog sled and repaired several others, they learned how to tie various knots, they went snowshoeing and learned the science behind weight distribution over an area, they learned the history of dog mushing and the history of Huslia, they were taught from the elders about how to live a healthy life, how to show respect and to be proud of their native heritage, they wrote dozens of "thank you" letters to outside sponsors of the program, they gave service to elders in the community, they wrote journal entries about their participation in the program, they read, discussed, and wrote about the native stories specific to Huslia.

As you can clearly see this program was seamlessly woven through all academic areas. I personally noticed a tremendous improvement in the behavior, attitude, and academic capabilities of my students from before the starting of the program activities in the late fall to their end in the spring.

For several of my students participating in the youth dog sled mushing program was a huge confidence booster. Their study habits and academic skills improved as a direct result I believe.

I cannot emphasize enough how much having this program be a part of the school day has helped to bring the whole community together rallying behind their students and integrated the school back into the community and the community in the school. If teachers are going to truly reach these students in a powerful and meaningful way it is imperative that they have the help of experts. The experts being the people who know these kids best, their family and neighbors. After all the progress that has been made and all the effort of the community to build this program and make it a rich part of these students education please don't let that dynamic school community connection be severed when it can and will only grow to positively impact many more generations to come.

Sincerely,
Samuel Barney
191 Reynolds Rd
FBKS, AK 99712
907-388-2948



Yukon Koyukuk School District
Administrative & Support Offices
4762 Old Airport Way
Fairbanks, Alaska 99709

Kerry Boyd
Superintendent
kboyd@yksd.com

Telephone: (907) 374-9400
Fax: (907) 374-9440

August 15, 2014

Dear George Attla and Kathy Turco,

I am writing to inform you what a difference the Frank Attla Youth Dog Mushing Program has made in Jimmy Huntington School and in the Huslia community. Over the last couple of years, the high school students have improved test scores, and attitudes. I know firsthand how it improves children's grades, keeps kids safe, benefits families and has a positive effect on the entire community.

The program provides an opportunity for students to learn from school-based environment and then applied the skills they learned through hands-on activities, which are culturally relevant. Students in this program learn skills preparing the students for a career in veterinary science.

Students in this program do better in math, reading and other subjects; have fewer behavioral problems; and have better attendance records. One of the best things about the program is the way it brings together various community members and gets them actively involved in helping kids learn more about their culture.

The YKSD is committed to preparing each of our students for college and a career. This program helps students to understand the relevance of an education and develop work-based skills. This program aligns with our vision of "Every learner will attain excellence and learn with passion in a challenging and culturally enriched environment." This program allows this vision to be fulfilled. Not only do the students gain academic skills, this program also helps them to become contributing members of their community and society.

Thank you for your partnership in education.

Sincerely,

Kerry Boyd
Superintendent

September 5, 2014- University of Alaska-Fairbanks Department of Veterinary Medicine
Dean, Dr. Arleigh Reynolds, presents to the YKSD School Board

Talking Points: The relationship between *Frank Attla Youth & Sled Dog
Care-Mushing Program* and the University of Alaska

- a. Programs like the Frank Attla Youth & Sled Dog Program are an ideal way to inspire young people to think about where they came from, who they are, what their possibilities are, and to think about themselves as part of a co-operative community.
- b. Success in this program is seen as an inspiration to try similar programs that teach school subjects in a way that is relevant to the students and therefore gets and holds their attention and interest.
- c. The success of the Frank Attla Youth & Sled Dog has also gained the attention of members of other communities in other school district who can see not only the direct educational benefits, but also the benefits to the community as a whole.
- d. When these students are taught by their elders, and their parents work together to help them reach their goals, the entire community benefits and becomes stronger. This may be the most valuable result of this program and is why other communities are trying to put similar programs in place in their school systems.
- e. It is our hope that some of these students will want to pursue college education in biology and biomedical fields such as veterinary medicine.
- f. Veterinary medical education for these students could be customized to meet the needs of rural communities so training for Emergency medical technician, food and water safety, as well as traditional veterinary medical training would be available. Such students returning to their communities would be seen as health officials to help in all aspects of public health not just Veterinary Medicine.
- g. We are currently developing scholarships and working with government and Native corporation officials to ensure jobs for these students would be available in the villages if they choose to go back to rural areas to work after graduation

Village Mushing Deserves Backup

Posted: Thursday, March 26, 2015 8:48 pm

Gilbert Huntington

News-Miner Community Perspective:

I recently had the good fortune to witness an exceptional event of Alaska life in Huslia. The decision to route the Iditarod trail through the village this year was truly historic and very good. Not because it was once the hotbed of mushing, or that no other village has produced more champion mushers, or the fact it was the home and final resting place of the “Huslia Husler” George Attla — although I must say, it was a fitting tribute to the late champion to have 75 teams traveling within a few hundred yards of his grave.

I thought it was indeed appropriate. The mushers I was able to visit were unanimously praising the trail and especially the reception they received. My personal thanks goes to the people in Huslia for their hospitality, although I had already been aware of it, having been born there and having traveled back there several times per year.

It was an emotional experience for all who were there when the first musher arrived. An official mentioned that he didn’t think it was ever any louder at the finish in Nome. They even had a countdown (needed for the second pool for the time of arrival). It will be one finish I will always remember. What was truly remarkable were all the children looking to interact with any musher they could. One musher toward the back of the pack mentioned they are usually ignored and he felt like a “rock star” for the attention he received from them. Having followed the Iditarod every chance I could since the beginning, I don’t recall so many kids seeking autographs.

I believe this is the result of the Frank Attla Youth and Sled Dog Care Mushing Program started by the late George Attla. With the foresight of the Yukon-Koyukuk School District and their help to include it into the curriculum for the Jimmy Huntington School in Huslia, we witnessed the phenomenon of these children sprouting from our stereotypical view of the shy village kid who tries to just blend into the background. Having been one of them, I can’t tell you how happy I felt. A special thanks to all the mushers who put up with it (at times, the kids were lined up). Having seen top-tier mushers before, many who may have been a bit aloof, it was great.

I firmly believe these kids will continue to benefit from this program. We may never see a future mushing champion come out of it, but we will surely continue to witness this remarkable “sprouting” of their human nature as a result. I hope and pray the Yukon-Koyukuk school board continues to support this program. Not only they, but the University of Alaska system should get involved in finding ways to better prepare kids who will become their students in the future.

One thing I’m afraid of is that with the passing of George this program might die as well. Fortunately, the same people who were the backbone of the program are still going forward. Not unlike many other good things in life that we benefit from, this program needs our help. I hope all who love Alaska, dog mushing — and, most of all, our future — will support it. Our great state can only get better with a program such as this one. No doubt it can be a model for others to follow and the future will be better for our kids, the dog mushing world and the Alaska we all love.

I had the good fortune to visit with George in the hospital before his passing. He said: “You know, after all that I’ve done in my life, the only thing that means anything is the path we leave for our kids. It’s too bad I figured it out this late in life.” I say the path they laid creating this program leaves George a good way to go out a champion. In my last words with him, I asked if there was anything I could do for him. The only thing he said was: “I know you’ll back me up.” May he view these few words as a little “backup.”

Gilbert Huntington is a long-time dog musher, commercial fisherman and big game guide from Galena, Alaska. He is the son of Sidney Huntington.